Fortnightly cetuximab + irinotecan

Cetuximab on Day 1. Irinotecan is given on Day 1; no home fluorouracil pump. A repeating 14-day cycle. The number of cycles depends on benefit, side effects and your treatment plan.

Draft — independent clinical, pharmacy and patient/PPI review pending. Selected effects; not a complete medicine leaflet.

A picture of side effects

Numbered symptom boxes connect to the anatomical illustration. The medicine responsible may be uncertain; report the symptom.

1 Eyes

Cetuximab

Eye pain or new visual change needs prompt advice.

2 Mouth / swallowing

Treatment

Pain or ulcers affecting eating or drinking need advice.

3 Breathing / reaction

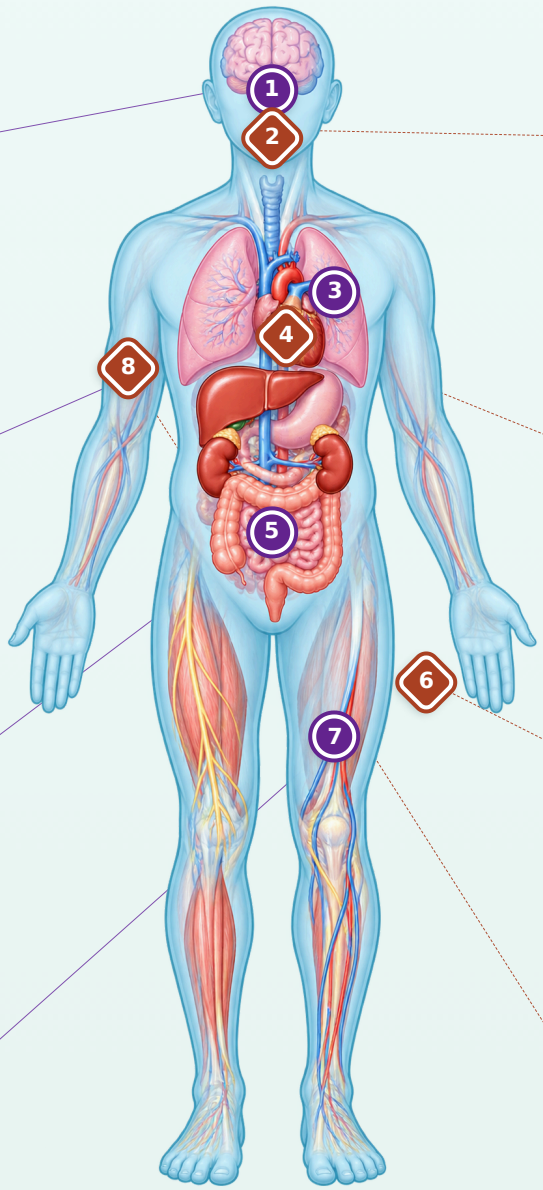
Cetuximab

New breathing difficulty requires prompt assessment.

4 Chest

Treatment

New chest pain needs urgent assessment.



5 Bowel

Irinotecan

Diarrhoea, increased stoma output or dehydration: call early.

6 Skin / nails

Cetuximab

Report painful rash, cracks or infected skin early.

7 Blood / infection

Treatment

Fever, shivers or sudden illness: contact oncology immediately.

8 Infusion access

Treatment delivery

Pain, swelling, leakage or a loose connection needs immediate advice.

Selected effects, not every possible effect or a prediction. Blood-count, skin and line markers are schematic. Number and text carry meaning; colour is decorative.

Fever, shivers or suddenly unwell: contact oncology immediately. Severe chest pain, breathing difficulty, collapse or seizure: 112 / 999.

NCCP 00331 · PRACTICAL SUPPORT

Your treatment, at home.

Important medicine-specific effects

Cetuximab

- Rash, dry skin, cracks and sore nails
- Eye inflammation or corneal injury
- Low magnesium, calcium or potassium
- Diarrhoea, dehydration and kidney problems
- Infusion reaction; rare serious lung or skin effects

Irinotecan

- Early cramps, sweating and diarrhoea
- Delayed diarrhoea and dehydration
- Low blood counts / serious infection
- Nausea, mouth soreness and fatigue
- Hair thinning or loss
- Rare serious lung or allergic reactions

Make the plan practical

Skin, nails and minerals

Start the prescribed skin-care plan early, use moisturiser and sun protection, and report painful or infected skin or nails. Keep mineral blood-test appointments during treatment and for two months after cetuximab.

Bowel symptoms and fluids

Irinotecan can cause early cramps/sweating during infusion and delayed diarrhoea after 24 hours. You need separate instructions for each. Follow your written rescue plan. Fever, blood, severe pain, reduced urine or inability to drink needs urgent advice.

Plan the visit

Allow for blood tests, review, pharmacy preparation, infusion and observation. A port is not automatically required; ask which access is suitable.

Comfort and daily life

Use prescribed anti-sickness medicines, pace activities and ask for nutritional, emotional or practical support.

Emergency: 112 / 999. Severe breathing difficulty, collapse, seizure or severe chest pain needs emergency help.

Contact oncology immediately for temperature ≥37.5°C or ≤36°C, shivering or suddenly feeling unwell, even with a normal temperature. Follow your own hospital's instructions. If you cannot reach the team, seek urgent medical assessment.

CUH · MON–FRI 8AM–5PM

087 181 9645

Acute Oncology Service

CUH · WEEKENDS / BANK HOLIDAYS 9AM–5PM

021 4922000

Ask for medical oncology

EVENINGS / OVERNIGHT

Your out-of-hours pathway / nearest ED

Other hospitals: use the numbers your team provides.

Complete reference, visual timeline and passport

https://sactcheck.com/patient/00331/

Sources and review status are available online. Follow your own prescription and hospital instructions.